far away from their heartland; their naval prowess was insufficient for long-term overseas colonization. Others assert that the Cholas left a viceroy in Java, creating longer-lasting political influence.[30] Disagreement among historians about the circumstances notwithstanding, the fact of an Indian empire extending its political influence outside of the subcontinent demonstrated the willingness of some Indian rulers – and their advisers – to expand India's sphere of influence as early as the eleventh century.



Just as ancient Indian philosophy casts its shadow on the orientation of Indian foreign policy, another long-lasting legacy of the medieval era is the religious and cultural pluralism that came with the rise of Muslim sultanates and the establishment of the Mughal Empire. The sultans of medieval India, as well as the Mughal emperors, were Muslims from outside India who made the subcontinent their home. They came to India from Persia and Central Asia, bringing with them the threat of further invasions from rival Muslim dynasties.

Under the Mughals, India became cognizant of the need to secure ties with the predominantly Muslim west and north-west – a policy consideration that remains paramount even today. In strategic terms, the Mughals knew that in order to safeguard their empire from rival rulers in Persia and Central Asia they needed control of the key forts of Kabul and Kandahar (present-day Afghanistan). A weak or friendly Central Asian ruler would be beneficial as it meant that the Mughals needed to spend fewer resources on safeguarding their empire's border. The British continued with the policy of building buffer zones along India's northern frontiers and modern India acquired that outlook.

The Mughals also had emotional reasons for seeking to extend their influence into Central Asia. The founder of the empire, Babur, was a Central Asian prince from the principality of Fergana (present day